



Privacy Policy

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This Privacy Policy explains how **DesignLynk** ("DesignLynk", "we", "us") collects, uses, shares, and protects your personal information when you use the DesignLynk website (designlynk.co.za) and web application (app.designlynk.co.za) (together, the "Service").

We are committed to protecting your privacy in accordance with the **Protection of Personal Information Act, 2013 (POPIA)** of South Africa.

Fill in before publishing: Responsible party legal name **[DesignLynk (Pty) Ltd]**, registration number **[_____]**, registered address **[_____]**.

1. Who is responsible for your information

The responsible party (data controller) is **[DesignLynk (Pty) Ltd]**.

Our **Information Officer** can be contacted at **privacy@designlynk.co.za** for any privacy questions, requests, or complaints.

2. The personal information we collect

We collect only what we need to run the marketplace:

You give us:

- **Account details** — name, email address, password (stored only as a secure one-way hash), and whether you are a designer or a client.
- **Profile information** — display name, bio, location, profile picture and banner image, and (for designers) headline, skills, years of experience, hourly rate, LinkedIn URL, CV/resume link, and education; (for clients) company name, industry, company size, typical hire, and website.
- **Content you submit** — job/contract posts, proposals and cover letters, project details, and connection requests.

We collect automatically:

- **Technical data** — IP address and basic request information, used for security, abuse prevention, and keeping the Service running.
- **A login token** stored in your browser's local storage so you stay signed in. We do **not** use advertising or third-party tracking cookies.

Images: profile pictures and banners you upload are stored in our own database. On upload we strip embedded metadata (such as GPS/EXIF data) and re-encode the image, so location and camera details in your original file are **not** retained.

3. How and why we use your information

Purpose	POPIA lawful basis
Create and manage your account	Performance of our agreement with you
Display your profile and match designers with clients	Performance of the agreement; your consent
Enable proposals, projects, connections, and messaging	Performance of the agreement
Keep the Service secure and prevent abuse	Our legitimate interests
Respond to your support requests	Performance of the agreement; legitimate interests
Comply with legal obligations	Compliance with the law

We do **not** sell your personal information.

4. Who we share it with

We share personal information with **operators** (processors) who help us run the Service, under agreements requiring them to protect it:

- **Neon** — managed PostgreSQL database (data hosted in the EU/UK, London region)
- **Fly.io** — application/API hosting (London region)
- **Netlify** — web app hosting
- **GoDaddy** — domain/DNS

Other users see the parts of your profile you choose to make visible (for example, your public designer or client profile, and information shared when you connect or submit a proposal).

We may disclose information if required by law, to protect our rights, or in connection with a business transfer.

We are **not** currently using any AI processor, analytics provider, or payment processor. If that changes, we will update this Policy first.

5. Cross-border transfers

Our hosting providers store data on servers in the **European Union / United Kingdom**.

Where personal information is transferred outside South Africa, we ensure it receives a level of protection consistent with POPIA (section 72), through providers that are subject to comparable data-protection laws and contractual safeguards.

6. How we protect your information

- Passwords are stored only as salted one-way hashes (never in plain text).
- The Service is served over encrypted HTTPS connections.
- Uploaded images are validated, stripped of metadata, and re-encoded.
- Access to personal information is limited to what is needed to operate the Service.

No system is perfectly secure, but we take reasonable, appropriate technical and organisational measures to safeguard your information.

7. How long we keep it

We keep your personal information for as long as your account is active. If you delete your account or ask us to, we will delete or de-identify your personal information within a reasonable period, except where we must retain it to comply with the law or resolve disputes.

8. Your rights under POPIA

You have the right to:

- **Access** the personal information we hold about you;
- **Correct or update** inaccurate or incomplete information (much of this you can do directly on your profile);
- **Delete** your information or **object** to certain processing;
- **Withdraw consent** where we rely on it; and
- **Lodge a complaint** with the Information Regulator.

To exercise any of these, email privacy@designlynk.co.za.

Information Regulator (South Africa)

Email: infoereg@justice.gov.za / POPIAComplaints@infoeregulator.org.za

Website: <https://infoeregulator.org.za>

9. Children

The Service is not intended for anyone under **18**, and we do not knowingly collect information from children. If you believe a child has provided us information, contact us and we will delete it.

10. Changes to this Policy

We may update this Policy from time to time. If we make material changes, we will update the "Last updated" date and, where appropriate, notify you in the app.

11. Contact us

Questions or requests: privacy@designlynk.co.za.

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